Voice of the Voiceless

Franchise Extension, the Press and Parliamentary Speech in the Netherlands, 1888–1925

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Representatives speak for those who can vote. Before they could vote, industrial workers and women already had newspapers that spoke for them. This paper asks what changed in parliament when they obtained the vote. It runs the logic of the 1869 press shock in reverse: the Dutch electorate roughly doubled in 1888 and nearly doubled again in 1897, with no comparable change in the price of news.

Question

When the franchise widened, public spending moved towards the new voters, in American states that dropped poll taxes and literacy tests or gave women the vote (Husted and Kenny 1997; Miller 2008). The political economy of democratisation explains who obtained the vote and what followed (Acemoglu and Robinson 2000; Lizzeri and Persico 2004; Aidt et al. 2006), including how franchise extension changed parliamentary speech (Spirling 2016). It rarely asks who had a voice before the vote. Parliamentary attention tracks the attention of newspapers (Walgrave et al. 2008; Vliegenthart et al. 2016), and newspapers cover what sells to readers and advertisers (Strömberg 2004). In the decades before their enfranchisement, newspapers made claims on behalf of workers and, later, women, so readers and voters were distinguishable populations.

If legislators follow the press because its readers can sanction them, enlarging the reading electorate should raise responsiveness most where newspapers reached the newly enfranchised. If they follow it as a source of information, the press carried these claims before the vote, and enfranchisement should leave press-following unchanged. The paper also asks whether enfranchisement changes how a group is represented more than how much it is discussed.

Setting

Reform	First election	Change
Constitutional revision of 1887	6 March 1888	Electorate roughly doubled. 100 seats in 84 districts (79 single-member, 5 multi-member city districts). Eerste Kamer enlarged to 50
Electoral law of 1896 (Van Houten)	15 June 1897	Electorate nearly doubled. New categories of voters (rent, wages, savings, diplomas). City districts split into 100 single-member districts
Constitutional revision of 1917	3 July 1918	Universal male suffrage and proportional representation. Districts abolished
Women's suffrage (1919)	5 July 1922	First national election in which women voted

Sources: Huygens ING election repository, de Jong (2017) and the constitutional texts.

The reforms of 1888 and 1897 changed who could vote in a press that had been growing since 1869 (Figure 1). The revision of 1887, first applied in 1888, redrew 43 districts into 84, so

outcomes are mapped onto common boundaries with municipality-overlap weights. In 1897 the city districts were split and 79 of the 84 districts kept their boundaries until 1918.

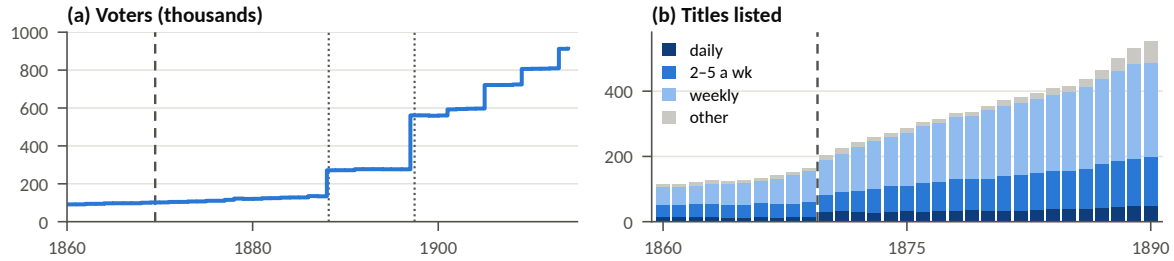


Figure 1. Voters and newspapers. (a) Registered voters, summed over electoral districts. (b) Newspaper titles in the booksellers' address books by frequency of appearance. Dashed lines: 1 July 1869, the repeal of the newspaper stamp. Dotted lines: first elections after the franchise extensions of 1887 and 1896. Sources: Huygens ING, and Hemels (1969) digitised for this project.

Data

- **Parliament.** The proceedings of both chambers from Staten-Generaal Digitaal, harvested for 1848–1940 (214,254 OCR pages) and segmented into 336,747 speeches, linked to members by chamber, sitting date, service spells and the person identifiers of the election returns.
- **Elections and districts.** Huygens ING district results with candidate votes and district composition (1848–1918), Kiesraad district totals, party votes for 1888–1917 (Verhoef 1992) and NLGIS boundaries.
- **Tax assessments and population.** The HDNG municipal series (population, religion, occupations and personal-tax assessments) and the population censuses.
- **Census tables of the electoral law.** The parliamentary papers that printed them, being harvested from Staten-Generaal Digitaal, to be transcribed by a language model and checked by hand.
- **Press presence before the reforms.** Every title in the booksellers' address books, 1851–1890, with place of publication, days of appearance and price, digitised from Hemels (1969) as a title-year panel of 1,237 titles.
- **Press content after 1879.** Article text from Delpher under a research agreement with the Koninklijke Bibliotheek. Yearly KB n-grams and Textcavator provide fallback series.

Measurement

The dose is the number of new voters the national rule would have created in each district, predicted from the district's structure before the reform: assessments per head, and occupations and housing from the last census before it. It depends only on the district before the reform and on the law, so the effort of parties or newspapers to register voters cannot move it. It instruments the actual increase in registered voters, and the estimate is an effect per new voter, a simulated instrument in the sense of Currie and Gruber (1996).

Outcomes are measured on the district representative:

- Press-following, from the phrases and the policy areas each member shares with the press of the previous month, as in the companion paper on 1869.
- Attention to the issues of the newly enfranchised (labour, housing, poor relief, public health, the franchise), from a policy-area classifier trained on language-model labels and checked

against blind human coders.

- The representation gap of each group g without the vote, $G_g = \log[(x_g + \epsilon)/(z_g + \epsilon)]$, where x_g is the share of press content advancing the group's claims and z_g the corresponding share of parliamentary speech. Two measures of a passage's group check each other: the language model's tag of the group whose conditions or claims it discusses, and group lexicons expanded with embeddings trained per decade, because referring expressions drift and a fixed dictionary would manufacture a trend.

Empirical strategy

Each reform is a difference-in-differences across districts with a continuous dose. The reduced form traces the response by year,

$$y_{dt} = \alpha_d + \lambda_t + \sum_{k \neq -1} \theta_k \, \widehat{\Delta E}_d \, \mathbf{1}[t - t^* = k] + \gamma_t' x_d + \varepsilon_{dt},$$

where $\widehat{\Delta E}_d$ is the predicted dose, t^* the first election under the new rules and x_d the district's structure before the reform, whose year-specific coefficients keep the dose from standing in for wealth or industry. Two-stage least squares with the actual increase in registered voters gives the effect per new voter. Districts with high predicted doses were more urban and industrial and might have changed anyway, so the pre-reform coefficients must be flat. Comparisons across doses identify causal responses only under strong parallel trends (Callaway et al. 2024), which the paper states and probes.

The 1888 reform is the stronger case, because new voters qualified through their tax assessments. In 1897 the new categories lay outside the tax rolls, and parties worked to put their supporters on the lists (de Jong 2017), so the instrument matters most. Interacting the dose with pre-reform newspaper presence links the designs back to the press. Inference uses wild-cluster bootstrap p-values over districts (Cameron et al. 2008).

From 1918 universal male suffrage and proportional representation arrived together and the districts disappeared. The years 1918–1925 are therefore analysed descriptively, through event-time series of the representation gap around universal male suffrage (first used in 1918) and women's suffrage (first used in 1922).

Hypotheses

- **H3, accountability in reverse.** Franchise extensions raise district representatives' press-following and their attention to the issues of the newly enfranchised in proportion to the increase in the electorate that the new rules predict, and more so where newspapers were present before the reform.
- **H4, voice before the vote.** Enfranchisement raises parliament's attention to the claims the press made for a group more than its attention to the group as such. The form of representation changes more than its volume.

Contribution

The paper brings the identification strategies of the media-and-accountability literature (Snyder and Strömberg 2010; Gentzkow et al. 2011) to the democratisation question, with a dose that registration campaigns cannot move. It measures, in a long parliamentary series, how the gap between what the press demanded for the voteless and what parliament discussed moved at enfranchisement. With its companion paper on the 1869 repeal of the newspaper stamp, it tests

the same channel from opposite directions: first the price of news changes with the electorate fixed, then the electorate changes with the price of news fixed.

Status

No estimate of this paper exists yet. The parliamentary corpus to 1940 is segmented, the election returns, municipal series and title census are assembled, and the parliamentary papers that printed the census tables are being harvested. The statutory thresholds of 1887 and 1896 are still to be transcribed from the Staatsblad, and post-1879 newspaper text depends on the agreement with the Koninklijke Bibliotheek. The specifications are registered in a pre-analysis plan before the doses are computed.

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